9MARKS BUILDING HEALTHY CHURCHES

What Is the Gospel?

Understanding the Good News that Changes Everything

Greg Gilbert

Foreword by D. A. Carson

> *"Greg Gilbert has written a penetrating, faithful, and fully biblical understanding of the gospel of Jesus Christ. There is no greater need today than to know the true gospel..."*
>
> **— R. Albert Mohler Jr., President of SBTS**

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ENDORSEMENTS & CONTENTS

"Greg Gilbert is someone I have had the honor of teaching and who is now teaching me. This little book on the gospel is one of the clearest and most important books I've read in recent years."

— MARK DEVER, Senior Pastor, Capitol Hill Baptist Church

"A wonderful telling of the old, old story in fresh words—and with sound warnings against subtle misrepresentations. Those who know the old story best will find themselves hungering to hear it again."

— BRYAN CHAPELL, President, Covenant Theological Seminary

"Gilbert, with a sharp mind and a pastor's heart, clears up misconceptions about the gospel, the kingdom, and the meaning of the cross. I've been waiting for a book like this!"

— KEVIN DEYOUNG, Author and Senior Pastor

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PREFATORY MATERIALS

Foreword & Introduction

Foreword by D. A. Carson

In an age where the word *gospel* is attached to everything from social causes to motivational self-help, defining its precise biblical content is not an academic exercise—it is a matter of spiritual life and death. The Christian church continually faces the danger of assuming the gospel in one generation, neglecting it in the next, and losing it entirely thereafter.

Greg Gilbert performs an invaluable service by directing our gaze back to Scripture. He does not offer a novel reinterpretation or a trendy revision; rather, he systematically uncovers the core architecture of the Good News as declared by Jesus and His apostles.

Introduction: The Importance of Getting It Right

What is the gospel? Ask five different churchgoers today, and you might receive five vastly different answers. Some will say it is "God loves you and has a wonderful plan for your life." Others will describe it as "working for justice and restoring the world." Still others view it simply as "living like Jesus lived."

If we get the gospel wrong, we get Christianity wrong. The apostle Paul issued the strongest possible warning in Galatians 1:8, stating that even if an angel from heaven should preach a gospel contrary to the one originally proclaimed, let him be accursed.

CORE THESIS OF THE BOOK

The biblical gospel is not a general message of self-improvement or social reform. It is a specific historical announcement centered on four indispensable pillars: **God, Man, Christ, and Response**.

CHAPTER 1

Finding the Gospel in the Bible

To understand the gospel, we must look to Scripture itself rather than culture or tradition. When we examine the New Testament—specifically Paul's systematic exposition in Romans and the apostolic sermons in Acts—we discover a consistent, structured framework.

In Romans 1–4, Paul constructs the gospel argument meticulously. He begins not with human felt needs, but with God's holiness and rightful wrath against human unrighteousness. From there, he establishes universal guilt, presents the substitutionary sacrifice of Jesus, and calls for personal faith.

1. GOD

The righteous Creator of all things to whom all human beings are morally accountable.

2. MAN

Rebellious sinners who have broken God's law and fall under His just wrath and condemnation.

3. CHRIST

The sinless God-man who died a substitutionary death on the cross and rose to redeem sinners.

4. RESPONSE

Repentance from sin and faith alone in Jesus Christ for justification and eternal life.

The Four Basic Questions

Gilbert points out that this four-part structure directly answers the four most critical questions every human being must confront:

1. **Who made us, and to whom are we accountable?** (God)
2. **What is our fundamental problem as human beings?** (Man / Sin)
3. **What is God's solution to that problem?** (Christ / Cross)
4. **How do I personally receive that salvation?** (Response / Faith & Repentance)

CHAPTER 2

God the Righteous Creator

The gospel does not begin with us; it begins with God. Modern presentations often start by assuring people of God’s unconditional love, but the biblical gospel starts with God as the almighty **Creator** and **Righteous Judge**.

1. God as Creator and Owner

Genesis 1:1 declares, "In the beginning, God created the heavens and the earth." Because God created everything, He owns everything—including every human being. Creation inherently establishes authority. God has the absolute right to command His creatures and set moral standards.

> *"The fundamental truth of human existence, the well from which all else flows, is that God created us, and therefore God owns us."*

2. God as Holy and Righteous

God is not merely powerful; He is morally perfect and holy. He cannot tolerate sin or treat evil with indifference. Exodus 34:6–7 describes God as merciful and gracious, yet explicitly adds that He "will by no means clear the guilty."

WARNING AGAINST MISCONCEPTIONS

Gilbert warns against viewing God as an *"unscrupulous janitor"* who simply sweeps human wrongdoing under the rug of benevolence. A God who ignores injustice is neither loving nor righteous.

CHAPTER 3

Man the Sinner

Having established who God is, Chapter 3 turns to the second pillar of the gospel: human nature and sin. Although humanity was created in the image of God to reflect His glory, we have radically rebelled against His authority.

The True Nature of Sin

Sin is not merely making mistakes or failing to live up to potential. At its core, sin is cosmic treason—a deliberate rejection of God's ruler-ship and right to command His creatures.

FOUR COMMON MISUNDERSTANDINGS OF SIN

- **Confusing sin with its effects:** Treating poverty or disease as sin rather than consequences.
- **Reducing sin to a broken relationship:** Forgetting sin is a judicial violation of God's law.
- **Confusing sin with negative thinking:** Reducing guilt to a psychological flaw.
- **Confusing sin with individual 'sins':** Ignoring the corrupt root nature that produces sinful acts.

Romans 3:23 states plainly: "All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God." Without understanding the depth of our predicament under God's righteous wrath, the mercy offered on the cross can never be appreciated.

CHAPTER 4

Jesus Christ the Savior

The third pillar of the gospel answers the crucial question: How can a holy God forgive sinful people without compromising His own righteousness? The answer lies entirely in the person and work of **Jesus Christ**.

1. The Person of Christ: Fully God and Fully Man

Jesus is not merely a moral teacher or religious prophet. He is the eternal Son of God made flesh (John 1:14). As true God, His sacrifice has infinite value; as true man, He can represent humanity and suffer in our place.

2. The Work of Christ: Penal Substitutionary Atonement

At the heart of the gospel is the cross. On the cross, Jesus lived the perfect sinless life we failed to live, and died the penalty-bearing death we deserved to die.

> **THE GREAT EXCHANGE**
>
> In 2 Corinthians 5:21, Paul explains: *"For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God."* Our sin was credited to Christ, and His righteousness is credited to believers.

3. The Resurrection and Vindication

Jesus did not remain in the grave. His physical resurrection on the third day declared with power that His sacrifice was accepted by the Father, sin and death were defeated, and He is established as King over all.

CHAPTER 5

Response: Faith and Repentance

Knowing the truth about God, Man, and Christ is not enough; the gospel demands an active, personal **response**. Salvation is not automatically applied to everyone; it must be received.

Two Sides of the Same Coin

The New Testament summarizes the required response to the gospel in two inextricably linked words: **repentance** and **faith** (Mark 1:15; Acts 20:21).

REPENTANCE

Turning away from sin, hating it as an offense to God, and turning toward God with a desire for holy obedience.

FAITH

Trusting entirely in the person and finished work of Jesus Christ—and nothing else—for salvation and justification.

Justification by Faith Alone (Sola Fide)

Gilbert emphasizes that faith is not a meritorious "work" that earns salvation. Faith is simply the empty hands that receive Christ's righteousness. We are justified—declared righteous before God—by grace alone, through faith alone, in Christ alone. Good works are not the root of salvation, but its necessary fruit.

CHAPTER 6

The Kingdom

In recent decades, many theologians have equated the gospel exclusively with the message of "the Kingdom of God." Gilbert clarifies how the Kingdom relates to the core cross-centered gospel message without confusing the two.

Understanding the Already / Not Yet

The Kingdom of God is God's redemptive reign in Christ. In Jesus' First Coming, the Kingdom was **inaugurated** ("already"), breaking into this present evil age. At His Second Coming, the Kingdom will be **consummated** ("not yet"), eradicating all sin, sorrow, and death.

> *"The Kingdom is the reality of God's rule through Christ; the Cross is the means by which sinners are forgiven so they can enter that Kingdom."*

Avoiding Kingdom Reductionism

Gilbert warns against framing the gospel merely as "God is fixing the world" while ignoring individual sin, atonement, and personal faith. We cannot participate in the blessings of the Kingdom without first being reconciled to the King through the cross.

CHAPTER 7

Keeping the Cross at the Center

Throughout history, churches and Christian movements have suffered from "gospel drift"—the subtle process of displacing the central message of Christ's substitutionary death with secondary issues.

TWO COMMON PITFALLS OF GOSPEL DRIFT

- **Replacing the Gospel with Social Action:** Confusing the *fruit* of the gospel (doing good works) with the *gospel itself* (the announcement of Christ's death for sin).
- **Assuming the Gospel:** Assuming that everyone in church already understands the cross, leading to a shift toward moralistic self-help preaching.

The Gospel as the Center of Church Life

The cross of Jesus Christ must remain the burning sun at the center of all Christian doctrine, preaching, worship, and practice. When the cross is marginalized, Christianity devolves into moralism, social activity, or dead legalism.

CHAPTER 8

The Power of the Gospel

In the concluding chapter, Gilbert reminds us of Paul's famous declaration in Romans 1:16: *"For I am not ashamed of the gospel, for it is the power of God for salvation to everyone who believes."*

1. Power to Transform Lives

The gospel is not a weak proposal; it is the divine instrument by which the Holy Spirit resurrects spiritually dead hearts, imparts eternal life, and brings genuine transformation to individuals and communities.

2. The Privilege and Call to Proclaim

Because the gospel alone contains the power to save, Christians and local churches are entrusted with a sacred heraldic mission. We are called to proclaim this message boldly, clearly, and without compromise to every nation and creature.

FINAL EXHORTATION

Hold fast to the old, old story. Know it thoroughly, guard its boundaries, treasure its grace, and proclaim it with joy to a world in desperate need of Good News.